

CESA'S GOLDEN YEARS

19 Years Old, 10 of Them Mine

*What I've figured out about keeping a senior dog comfortable, written from
our living room and not a clinic.*

Amanda · The Gentle Muse

Before you start

Her name is Princessa. Cesa. She's 19, she's a chihuahua, and I've had her for 10 of those years.

SAID PLAINLY, BEFORE ANYTHING ELSE

I'm not a vet. I'm not a trainer. I have no credentials of any kind. Everything in here is what I noticed, what I changed, and what I asked someone qualified about.

When something in your house looks different, the answer is your vet, not this guide. I'd rather be useful and honest than sound like an authority I'm not.

What I can tell you is what nobody told me.

Most of what I know I learned the slow way, by getting it wrong first and then paying closer attention. There was a stretch around year 16 where I was reading forums at 2 AM, trying to work out whether the thing she'd just done was normal or the beginning of something. Nobody handed me anything. So I wrote the thing I wanted back then.

It's short on purpose. None of it is complicated, and that's the point. You can read it in 20 minutes and put down 2 of these things this week.

We're not chasing more years. We're making the ones she has softer.

Those are different jobs and they need different decisions, and the second one is almost entirely within reach.

Her history, because it explains most of what follows

I met her in 2015. She was 8, she was a breeder dog, and she was not mine yet.

The adoption didn't finalize until 2016, because she was pregnant again. Her 3rd litter that I know of, at 9 years old.

Here's the part I want to say properly, because it's the whole reason any of this exists. I could have had one of her puppies. That was on the table. It's what most people would have taken, and nobody would have thought twice about it.

I wanted her. The 9 year old with the litters behind her, not the puppy with everything still in front of it.

I have never regretted that for a second. I do sometimes wish we'd been able to keep one of them with her, so she'd have had one of her own in the house. That one still gets me a little.

So, 2016. And 10 years since.

What happened in 2022

She had pyometra. It's an infection of the uterus, it happens to females who were never spayed, and it can turn serious quickly. I read everything I could find on it at the time, because I wanted to actually understand what was happening to her instead of nodding along in an exam room.

The treatment is spaying. At 15, that was not an easy thing to agree to, and I want to be honest that her vet was openly hesitant about putting a dog her age under anesthesia at all.

They found cancer during that surgery. Nobody was looking for it. It came out with everything else.

And afterwards, the same vet who hadn't wanted to operate said this to me:

You just added years to this little dog's life.

She's had 3 dentals as well, in 2020, 2021 and 2024.

The part the list leaves out

I want to say something about all that, because a history like this reads grim and her life has not been grim.

This is a dog who chased rabbits. Who went after squirrels with total commitment and no plan whatsoever. Who tried, more than once, to fight the neighborhood cats, and who I had to physically intervene with for her own safety, because she genuinely believed she could take them and she absolutely could not.

She's had a long, vibrant, ridiculous life. The medical history is part of it. It isn't the whole of it, and I'd rather you saw both.

CHAPTER 1

Walk the house at her height

This is the one I'd give you if you only took one.

Get on the floor. Actually do it, not a crouch. Lie down where she lies down and look at the room from there. I did this the first time feeling ridiculous and then spent the next hour changing things.

Standing up, you cannot see what she deals with. Here's what I found down there.

- **Every turn costs her something.** Count the steps from where she sleeps to where she drinks. Then count the turns. I took 2 turns out of that route by moving a chair and it's the single laziest improvement I ever made.
- **Transitions between rooms.** The little metal strip where tile meets carpet is nothing to you. It's a curb to her. Same with the lip on a door frame.
- **Light.** Her eyes aren't what they were and I didn't clock it for a long time, because dogs compensate so well you don't notice until they stop. A low nightlight near her route, not a bright one overhead, made her night trips less hesitant.
- **The corners at her head height.** Coffee table legs, the edge of a bed frame. Padding on 2 of them was enough.

The floor, and where I disagree with most of what you'll read

The standard advice is runners and rugs everywhere. For a lot of dogs that's exactly right. Old nails on hardwood have very little grip, and a dog who slips once starts bracing before she walks, and that bracing is its own kind of tired.

It didn't work for us. Cesa pees on rugs. We tried it, the accidents got worse, and the traction rugs that actually grip the floor are the same ones you can't easily pull up and wash. So we went backwards on purpose.

What I do instead is simpler. I pick her up. If she's going somewhere and the floor is a factor, she gets carried. She walks slowly and she doesn't actually slip much, and between the carrying and the pace it stopped being the problem I expected it to be.

I'm leaving the rug advice in here because it genuinely is right for a lot of houses. I just won't hand it to you as gospel when it failed in mine.

The 3 feet rule

She picked her spot in the kitchen years ago and she does not intend to renegotiate it. When I rearranged that room, I created a new path, and the new path went straight through where she sleeps. I was carrying something hot the first time I realized it.

So now, before I move anything, I tape out her spot on the floor. Painter's tape, 30 seconds. Then I plan around the tape.

Measure her spot before you rearrange the room, not after. Old dogs have the house memorized. To her, a chair in a new place isn't a redecoration, it's an obstacle that appeared overnight in a map she's been using for a decade.

And if you can help it, don't move things at all. Novelty is fun for you. It's work for her.

CHAPTER 2

Soft food, dentals, and what gumming actually means

Fair warning: this is the chapter where I most want to be clear that I'm out of my depth on the medical side. Everything here went past a vet before it became how we do things.

The day I noticed she was gumming her dinner

She was eating, but wrong. Picking a piece up, working it at the front of her mouth, putting it down. Doing that 3 or 4 times before actually swallowing anything. It took me embarrassingly long to see it, because the bowl was emptying, so I assumed dinner was fine.

The bowl emptying is not the same as dinner being fine. That's the sentence I wish someone had handed me.

I called the vet, and what came out of that conversation was about her teeth. I'm not going to pretend to explain the dental side, because I'd get it wrong and you'd deserve better. What I'll say is this: if the mechanics of eating look different, that's a vet conversation and not a food conversation, and I spent weeks treating it as a food conversation first.

What we changed after that, and it did help

- **Warm water on her food, 10 minutes before.** Not hot. It softens things and it brings the smell up, which matters more than I expected. Her nose is doing a lot of the work of deciding whether dinner is worth the effort.
- **I raised the bowl.** Eating off the floor means holding her head down and her neck at an angle for the whole meal. A few inches up, propped on a book at first because I was cheap about it, and she stayed at the bowl longer.
- **Smaller, more often.** Same food, split across 3 sittings instead of 2. She ran out of interest before she ran out of dinner, and spreading it out got more into her without any fight about it.
- **I stopped standing over her.** She eats better when I'm in the room but not watching. I don't know why. It's just true here.

The thing to actually keep an eye on

You can feel weight change before you can see it, especially on a small dog with any coat at all. Hands on her ribs and her spine once a week, same time, so you're comparing to something. I put a note in my phone.

Any change in how much she's eating, how fast, or what she weighs goes to your vet. Not to a guide. Not to a forum at 2 AM, and I say that as someone who has been on those forums at 2 AM.

CHAPTER 3

The 3 second stare

Every person with an old dog does this and nobody talks about it.

She's asleep in a shape that should not be comfortable. Back legs straight out behind her, chin flat on the floor, 1 ear folded under itself. And you stop whatever you're doing and you stand there and you watch her ribs until you see them move.

3 seconds. Then you go back to what you were doing.

I do it several times a day. I have never once been right to worry.

Telling her worry from yours

Here's the honest thing: most of the staring is mine, not hers. It's my anxiety about time, and she's just asleep. Learning to tell those apart is most of what makes this age livable, because you cannot sustain 19 years of adrenaline.

What I actually check, and it takes about as long as the stare:

- **Is she breathing evenly?** Not fast, not laboured, just even.
- **Could she get up if she decided to?** Not is she getting up. Could she.
- **Did she choose this position?** This is the real one. A weird position she picked herself is a weird position. A position she ended up in, in a spot she doesn't normally use, is a different thing and it's worth a closer look.

That last question sorts about 90 percent of it for me.

Write it down, because you cannot see patterns from inside them

This is the tip I'd fight for.

Get a note in your phone. One line, whenever something seems off. Date, and what you saw. Don't analyze it, don't decide what it means, just log it.

Day to day you'll notice nothing, because she changes slowly and you're with her constantly and your eye adjusts. Across 2 weeks a pattern will be obvious. Across 2 months it'll be undeniable.

That note is also the single most useful thing you can hand a vet. "She seems a bit off lately" is hard to work with. "These 6 dates, always in the evening, and always after she's been on the hard floor" is something someone can actually use.

The only genuinely useful question in the moment is **is this new**. Not is this bad. Just, is this new. And you can't answer that from memory. I've tried.

CHAPTER 4

Sleep, and which changes matter

She sleeps most of the day now. That, by itself, has never been the thing.

What turned out to be normal for us

- **Sleeping more, and deeper.** She's harder to wake than she used to be and that startled me at first. She's 19.
- **Alarming positions.** She has a repertoire and it's extensive and none of it has ever meant anything.
- **Twitching, running feet, the small noises.** Same as when she was 3.
- **Getting up slower.** This is the one that hurts to watch and it's just what's happening. She hears the car before the door, and by the time I'm inside she's already up, and getting up takes her longer than it used to. She still does it every single time. I'm not going to pretend that doesn't get me.

What I paid attention to instead

Not how much she sleeps. **Where, and whether the pattern changed.**

She has her spot. If she's sleeping somewhere she doesn't normally sleep, that's information. If she's suddenly picking the cold tile when she's always chosen the blanket, or the other way round, that's information.

Night waking and pacing was the one I took to the vet. Not because I knew what it meant, I didn't, but because it was new and it kept happening and it was in my notes with dates on it.

Temperature is a bigger deal than I understood. Small old dogs lose heat fast and she got cold in rooms that felt fine to me. A blanket she can get under rather than one laid over her, so she can decide. She uses it. That was a genuine comfort improvement for almost no money.

About accidents, briefly

She peed in my office and looked me dead in the eye about it. I got the towel. She watched me do it from her bed.

Here's what I'll say, carefully. At this age it's usually not defiance, and it isn't automatically the beginning of the end. In our case a lot of it came down to practical things: how far the door was, how much traction was on the route, and how long she could reasonably hold it. All 3 of those were things I could adjust, and adjusting them helped.

But whether that's what's happening in your house is a question for your vet, and it's worth asking early rather than deciding for yourself. I nearly didn't ask.

The 5 things I'd do differently in year 1

If I got a year 1 with her again.

- 1 **I'd have started the notes log years earlier.** Everything I know about her patterns, I know from about the last 3 years. The 7 before that are a blur and I have no baseline for any of it. It costs nothing and I'd have it forever.
- 2 **I'd have written her medical history down as it happened.** I had to go digging to put the years into this guide. 2020, 2021 and 2024 for the dentals, 2022 for the surgery, and I could not have told you a single one of those from memory. It all lives in my head in the wrong order. One page, dated, added to each time something happened. I'd give a lot for that page now.
- 3 **I'd have stopped asking her to hurry.** Around year 14 I finally quit rushing her out the door in the morning, and it turns out slow mornings were never the problem, my schedule was. She gets up when she gets up now. The mornings got better for both of us and I lost nothing I actually needed.
- 4 **I'd have asked the small questions instead of saving them up.** I used to bank 5 or 6 minor things for the next appointment, which meant every one of them went unanswered for months and 2 of them turned out to matter. Vets take questions between visits. I didn't know that for an embarrassingly long time.
- 5 **I'd have taken more boring photos.** I have plenty of her looking cute. I have almost none of her just lying on the floor in the room where I was working, which is what she actually did for 10 years. The ordinary ones are the ones I go back to. Take the boring photo.

The last part

Different rooms, different jobs, different stretches I didn't talk about out loud. The same small dog on the floor in the same 3 feet, chin down, waiting for me to be done with whatever it was.

She was never impressed by any of it. That was sort of the point of her.

If you're somewhere in this with your own dog, I hope 1 thing in here was useful. Don't do all of it. Pick the one that was easiest to picture in your house and do that this week. The rest will still be here.

And if you want to tell me your old dog's name and age, hit reply. I read every one, and I like knowing who this is for.

Amanda

with Cesa, asleep on my left foot as I write this

Free to share with anyone who needs it. Not veterinary advice, and not a substitute for your vet, who knows your dog and has the training I don't.